

in clutch knock out matches and bleeding rookie medium pacer Muhammed Irshad for a crucial league match.

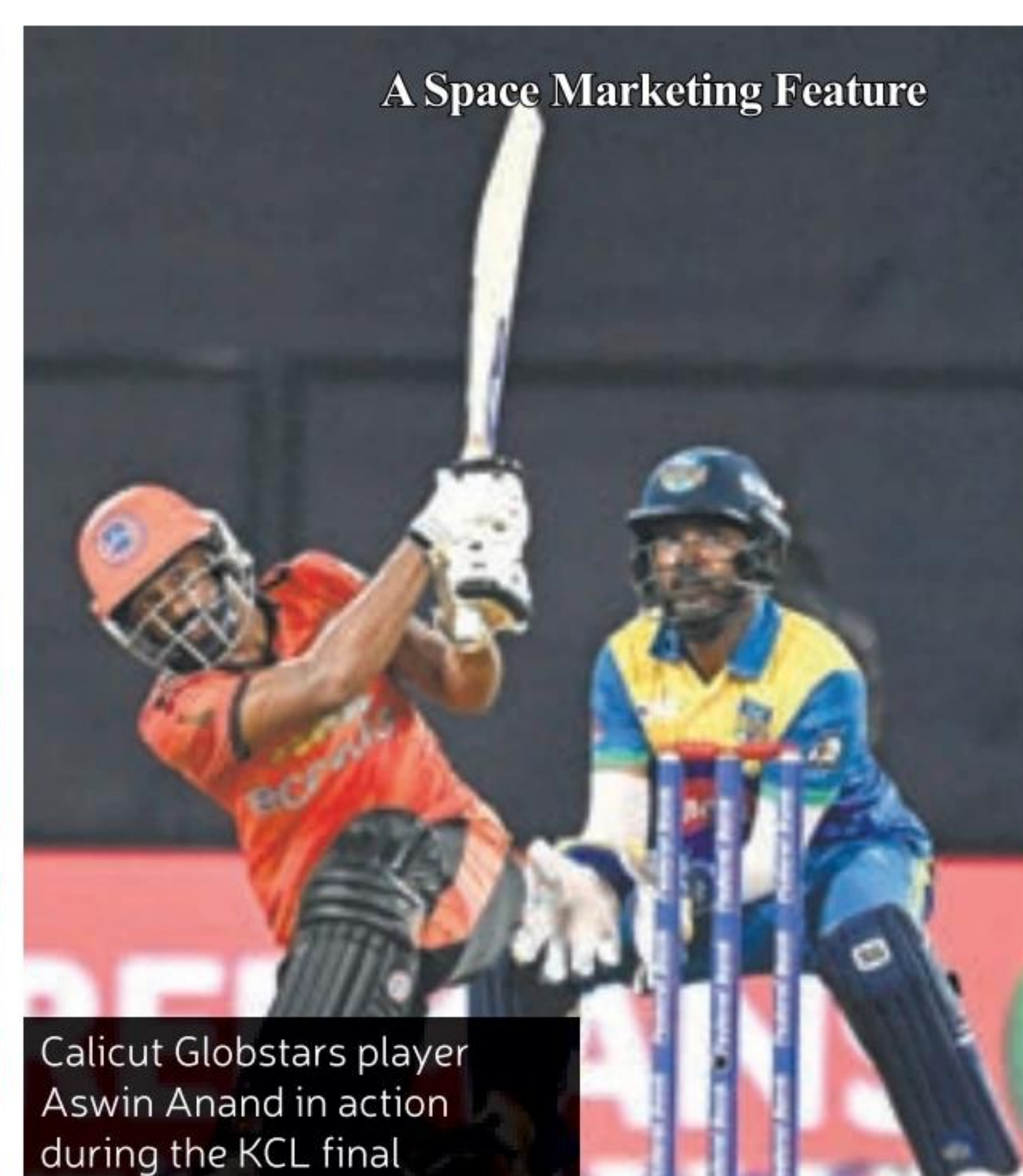
There were times when the young team cracked under pressure, losing three consecutive chases by small margins, and a choker image thrust on it. The turnaround for the Titans came in the crucial league match against the Calicut Globstars when a hobbling A.K. Arjun came out and smote Akhil Scaria for a six to pull out a last ball win. In the semifinal, it was medium pacer Anand Joseph whose unbeaten 16 off three balls clinched a humdinger for the Titans. Cognisant of his young side's vulnerability, Sunil always packed the sides with players who could bat. "Our batting depth put us in good stead in crunch situations. We had multiple heroes in our title triumph and vindication of our brave youth policy," he said.

The third edition of the KCL lacked elite star power, as Sanju Samson, the marquee face of the tournament, sat out due to personal reasons. His absence was a big blow to defending champion Kochi Blue Tigers which finished at the bottom of the table. Aries Kollam Sailors, the champion of the inaugural edition, also failed to qualify for the semifinals, finishing fifth in the league.

The league was a level playing



Thrissur Titans player Ahammed Imran in action during the KCL final



Calicut Globstars player Aswin Anand in action during the KCL final



Mohammed Azharuddeen receiving the player of the tournament award

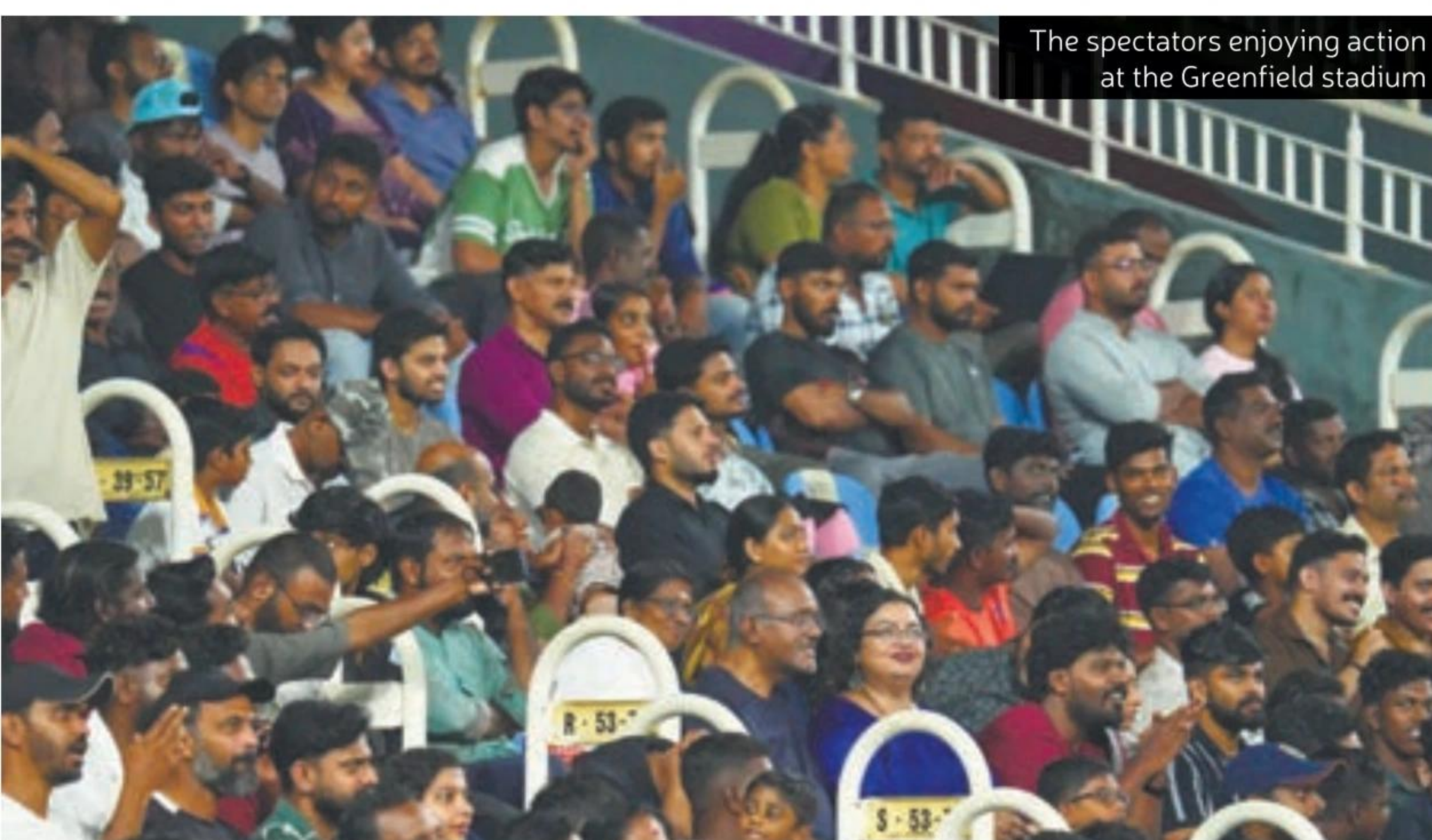
PHOTOS: NIRMAL HARINDRAN

field with all teams undergoing a massive overhaul. Two uncapped players Sabin Girish and Krishna Devan were the toast in the player auction. Sabin Girish, who was picked by the Alleppey Ripples, was the most expensive player to be sold at the auction for ₹11.8 lakh. Krishna Devan was bought

by the Calicut Globstars for ₹11.2 lakh. Their meteoric rise from obscurity highlighted the tournament's evolution into a genuine platform for local talent. Off the field, the Kerala Cricket Association (KCA) also took strategic steps to boost public engagement.



Road shows, Statewide fan cricket tournaments and fan parks generated significant buzz. A promotional film featuring Sanju and superstar Mohan Lal garnered 3.5 million views on Instagram and over 1.8 lakh views on YouTube. The league itself saw a substantial viewership spike on Starsports and Asianet Digital, culminating in a crowd of over 25,000 spectators witnessing the final, making season 3 the most successful edition in the KCL's history.



The spectators enjoying action at the Greenfield stadium